



The Writers' Exchange
207 – 877 E Hastings St.
Vancouver, BC. V6A 3Y1

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To whom it may concern,

Over the past nine years, I have had the pleasure of knowing Stephanie Slen, as the Managing Director of Writers' Exchange. Our community organization is based in East Vancouver, including the Downtown Eastside neighborhood, and supports under-resourced kids and youth in building confidence and developing a passion for reading and writing. The programs offered through Writers' Exchange provide opportunities for participants to connect with the community outside of school time. Fueled by the creativity and engagement of its participants, the organization strives to counteract structural barriers and encourage each kid and youth to build the confidence to understand their own potential.

I first met Stephanie when she was in elementary school through her attendance as a program participant. From the start, Stephanie has consistently stood out as an enthusiastic and motivated participant. I can always count on her to come into Writers' Exchange with an infectious positive attitude, a story to share, and a genuine interest in how others are doing. Stephanie constantly seeks opportunities to extend her involvement beyond the usual program time, as she loves to lend a hand, try new things, and has a genuine interest in community.

I first saw Stephanie's leadership qualities and initiative-taking abilities in grade five when she participated as a Writers' Exchange outreach volunteer at the Vancouver Art Book Fair. She encouraged adults to volunteer in programs at the Writers' Exchange and sold our books to raise money for the organization. Stephanie was outgoing, confident and excelled in this role, so we asked her to return annually for two additional Art Book Fairs. In grade seven, she spearheaded her own Writers' Exchange fundraiser in the form of a used book and clothing sale at our space on East Hastings. For this fundraiser, she organized the donations, set up the tables, and did all the sales and promotion for the event with two other participants. Even at a young age Stephanie demonstrated exemplary commitment and unmatched initiative.

Early on, I recognized Stephanie's strong leadership skills and invited her to take on a leadership role as staff at Writers' Exchange. She has been in this role for three years now. As a leader, Stephanie has translated her lived experience as an engaged participant into being a consistent and positive role model for kids in programs. One time a student arrived to program upset and I saw Stephanie take initiative to cheer them up. The kid was going away for a few weeks and was upset they were going to be absent from programs. So, Stephanie put together a care package of their favorite Writers' Exchange snacks to take with them while they were away. Her care and compassion for others comes naturally, however I've recognized the impact it makes on people she interacts with. Stephanie's passion for the Writers' Exchange community is clear. Because of her own experiences, she understands how well the Writers' Exchange can benefit kids and youth. Her numerous contributions have ensured that other young people receive encouragement and support to boost their confidence. Over the years I have seen Stephanie grow from being a young participant always excited to come to the program, to a strong community leader and advocate for those with similar lived experiences.



Throughout the years I witnessed her passion for sustainability, community, and working with young people expand beyond school and the Writers' Exchange. She has been involved in many community programs in the neighborhood as both a participant and a mentor. In recent years, she has participated in Sustainable Opportunities for Youth Leadership (SOYL), where she attended as a participant and was later invited to mentor the following year. Additionally, she has been actively engaged in Strathcona Interact Club as a sustainability coordinator, where she carried out the initiative "Adopt a Plant", and is the President of Beyond the Plate, a gardening and cooking club at her high school. In each initiative Stephanie participates in, she does so with dedication, empowerment, and compassion.

It is always such a joy to hear about everything Stephanie is involved in. She never fails to impress me with how well she manages her time between academics, being President of the school council, community leadership, cross country, and balancing her family and personal life. Stephanie grew up in an immigrant family household, living in subsidized housing, with parents that struggle with mental illnesses. The structural barriers accompanying this reality have created substantial obstacles to accessing post-secondary studies. Despite the hardships I have seen Stephanie encounter, I have watched her continue to maintain a positive outlook, persevering beyond any obstacle she faces. I am confident that if provided with the opportunity, Stephanie will thrive as a post-secondary student, and contribute meaningfully to the community and open doors for many more youth in the future.

Stephanie has grown with us as an organization. Since she was young, she has found comfort in our programs and has made lifelong connections with other youth, volunteers, and staff. She has inspired staff, volunteers, and board members at the Writers' Exchange to be creative and take on challenges with grit and good humor. Stephanie is a highly valued member of our community, her school community, and the neighborhood community. Through her leadership, dedication, and compassion, I am confident that she will be successful in her post-secondary education and her endeavors beyond that. Stephanie is committed to community, an impressive student with endless potential, and a deserving candidate for your scholarship.

Sincerely,

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